

RAmos T10

A PMP which sports 4.3-inch WQVGA display and has support for practically any audio / video format

Sony Ericsson

Launches its first outdoor Bluetooth speaker

Dell Adamo

Presumably the world's thinnest laptop. Will be available soon for about Rs. 1.02 lacs

Ask Agent001

Q I have decided on the following configuration for my first PC: Intel Q9550 CPU, MSI P45 Platinum Mobo, Corsair 2X2GB DDR II 800 RAM.

The problem is that I read your article on the Nehalem i7 CPU this month. It made me think again.

Is the i7 worth the extra Rs. 10,000 or so considering that DDR3 is costlier? Should I wait for the next price drop? The choice of graphics card is Palit HD4870 1 GB Sonic.

I'm also confused because SLI works better than the CrossFire because of game manufacturer support. In the future, will this change? I'm also considering an NVIDIA card because SLI works more consistently than CrossFire.

Abhijeet Kashid

Firstly, the i7 is worth the premium of Rs. 10,000. If you already had a reasonably fast system, I would recommend you wait a bit, as prices are expected to drop by August. Since you don't have a fast PC, I recommend spending a bit more and getting the i7. Unfortunately, even though the i7 920 is priced identically to the Q9550, you will pay a bit extra for an X58 motherboard and DDR3 memory. For the memory, I recommend Transcend 1333 MHz DDR3 that should cost you around Rs. 7,000 for a 4 GB kit. For the motherboard, Intel's own DX 58SO is available and will cost you Rs. 16,000. The Palit 4870 1 GB SONIC is a superb choice and represents great value and is decently future proof. It's also great for a CrossFire solution. The NVIDIA equivalent is the GTX 260 which is slightly costlier. The NVIDIA GTX 285 is a faster card, but is much costlier. In case CF is something you are looking at in the future, I recommend at least a CoolerMaster Real Power 850 W PSU which is priced at Rs 8,500. If you really want a monster PSU, the Corsair HX 1000 is unbeatable at Rs. 13,000. Do not try to save on the price of a PSU — this is one of the most important components in your PC and can damage other components. In case you do not want to opt for multi-GPU solutions, look at Corsair's TX 650-W PSU.

Q My budget is Rs 7,000 and I want to buy a PMP with good sound quality, about 8-16 GB of storage and nice looks. Also, tell me the price of an iPod Classic. Does it come in an 8-GB model?

Atul Bagde

The iPod Classic is available in a minimum size of 80 GB. It's a hard drive based PMP. Only flash-based players have smaller storage sizes in the range of 1 GB to 32 GB. If you really want a serious PMP, I recommend you up your budget by another Rs. 1,500 and get a Cowon D2. It's a great audio and video device and supports memory expansion as well. Alternatively, for Rs. 7,000, you could get the iPod Nano 4 GB, which is also a very good PMP.

Q I am planning to buy a Sony digital camera. Please suggest a good camera from the Sony Cybershot series. My budget is Rs. 10,000.

Prasanth P

Considering your budget, perhaps you might be better off taking a look at Canon. Canon models are priced better on the street. For Rs. 10,000, you could pick up an SX100 IS, which is an 8-MP camera with a 10x optical zoom. Alternatively, you could look at the A720 IS, which also has a sensor rated at 8-MP and has a 6x optical zoom. You will have to decide whether you want to pay extra for a bill or not. The difference could be as much as Rs. 2,000 between dealer prices and street prices.

Q I want to buy NVIDIA 9600 or 9800 GT cards. Which of these are more suitable for a gamer? I also want buy a low-cost motherboard with at least one PCI Express slot. Will a PCIe 2.0 slot be faster? Please help me choosing the peripherals.

Paltu Sharma

NVIDIA's GeForce 9800 GT is a much faster GPU than the 9600 GT. While the 9600 GT has 64 stream processors, the 9800 GT has 112, and is more of a mid-range option than the 9600 GT, which can be considered as an entry-level option. PCIe 2.0 is the latest generation PCIe slot. Other than the higher theoretical bandwidth than PCI 1.0, there isn't a big difference. Performance-wise, the difference is not more than 2-3 per cent. As of today, a PCIe 2.0 generation slot is not a necessity and will not be for another year, at least. The choice of motherboard should not be dictated by this feature. You have not mentioned which platform you want a motherboard for, but I'm assuming it's Intel based. I recommend a GeForce 9300-based solution if you're looking at an NVIDIA GPU, mainly because these boards support

hybrid power saving where either your GPU or your integrated graphics solution is used depending on what sort of application is being run. Zotac's GeForce 9300 is a good solution for you and is priced at Rs. 6,500.

Q I want to purchase a laptop. My budget is Rs. 70,000. The minimum requirement is:

CPU: Core 2 Duo 2.4 GHz, GPU: 512 MB (DX 10 supporting, NVIDIA preferred), RAM: 2 GB, HDD: 240 GB. I am a computer engineering student and a gamer as well. I am looking for Dell and Vaio laptops.

Akshay Dorwat

Look at the new Dell Studio XPS 16. It has everything you've listed and is suitable as a gaming notebook. The only thing is it uses an ATI graphics solution. It uses the ATI Radeon HD 3470 512 MB. The CPU used is the new Core 2 Duo P8600 (2.4 GHz). ■

How to clean your CD/DVDs

Old disks often acquire small specks of dust in the tracks that often cause read errors, responsible for the "cyclic redundancy error" message. Using a clean dry cloth to wipe them often helps, but not always. You can clean your disks with soap, and then wipe the disk dry before you insert it into the tray. Or spread Fevicol carefully in a circular motion, let it dry and peel of the layer from the disk using fingers not your nails. Wipe with soft dry cloth before using.